

TSEC Risk & Cyber Advisory

www.tsecgrc.com | Info@tsecgrc.com

P L A N T E M P L A T E

Incident Response Plan Template

TSEC Incident Response Series | Starter Template for Structured Incident Response

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TSEC Technical Data Sheet

Every resource published in the TSEC Compliance Library™ includes this standardized technical data sheet, summarizing the resource's identity, scope, and intended use at a glance.

Library	TSEC Incident Response Series
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About This Template

This starter template provides organizations with a structured foundation for documenting their incident response approach. It covers roles and responsibilities, incident classification, the response lifecycle, and the working documents a team needs during and after an incident.

Before you adopt or distribute this template, please note:

- It is designed as a **starting point** — not a finished plan.
- It **must be adapted** to your organization's structure, systems, and regulatory environment.
- It **does not substitute for a risk assessment** — your actual response priorities should be informed by your own risk analysis.
- It **does not constitute legal advice**. Notification obligations vary by jurisdiction, industry, and the nature of the incident.
- It should be **coordinated with Legal, Communications, HR, IT, and Management** as applicable before it is finalized and relied upon.
- It is **conceptually aligned with NIST SP 800-61** (the Computer Security Incident Handling Guide) but is not a reproduction of that publication and is not a substitute for consulting it directly.

01. Incident Response Plan — Document Control

Organization	[Organization Name]
Plan Owner	[Name / Role]
Executive Sponsor	[Name / Role]
Version	[Version]
Effective Date	[Date]
Review Date	[Date]
Approved By	[Name / Role]
Classification	[Internal / Confidential]

Revision History

Use this table to track changes to your organization's plan over time — separate from TSEC's own publication history at the end of this document.

Version	Date	Description	Author
[Version]	[Date]	[Description]	[Author]

Version	Date	Description	Author

02. Purpose

Sample starter language — adapt to your organization's context:

“The purpose of this Incident Response Plan is to establish a structured approach for identifying, assessing, responding to, containing, recovering from, and learning from cybersecurity incidents affecting the organization.”

03. Scope

Define what this plan covers. A typical scope spans three dimensions:

Dimension	Typically Includes
Systems	Corporate systems, cloud environments, endpoints, applications, network infrastructure.
Information	Customer information, employee information, confidential information, financial information, intellectual property.
Personnel	Employees, contractors, third parties, service providers.

04. Incident Response Roles & Responsibilities

Role	Responsibility	Primary Contact	Backup
Incident Response Lead	Coordinates response	[Name]	[Name]
IT/Security	Technical investigation and containment	[Name]	[Name]
Executive Management	Business decisions	[Name]	[Name]
Legal	Legal/regulatory guidance	[Name]	[Name]
Communications	Internal/external communications	[Name]	[Name]
HR	Personnel-related incidents	[Name]	[Name]
Third Party	External support	[Vendor]	[Contact]

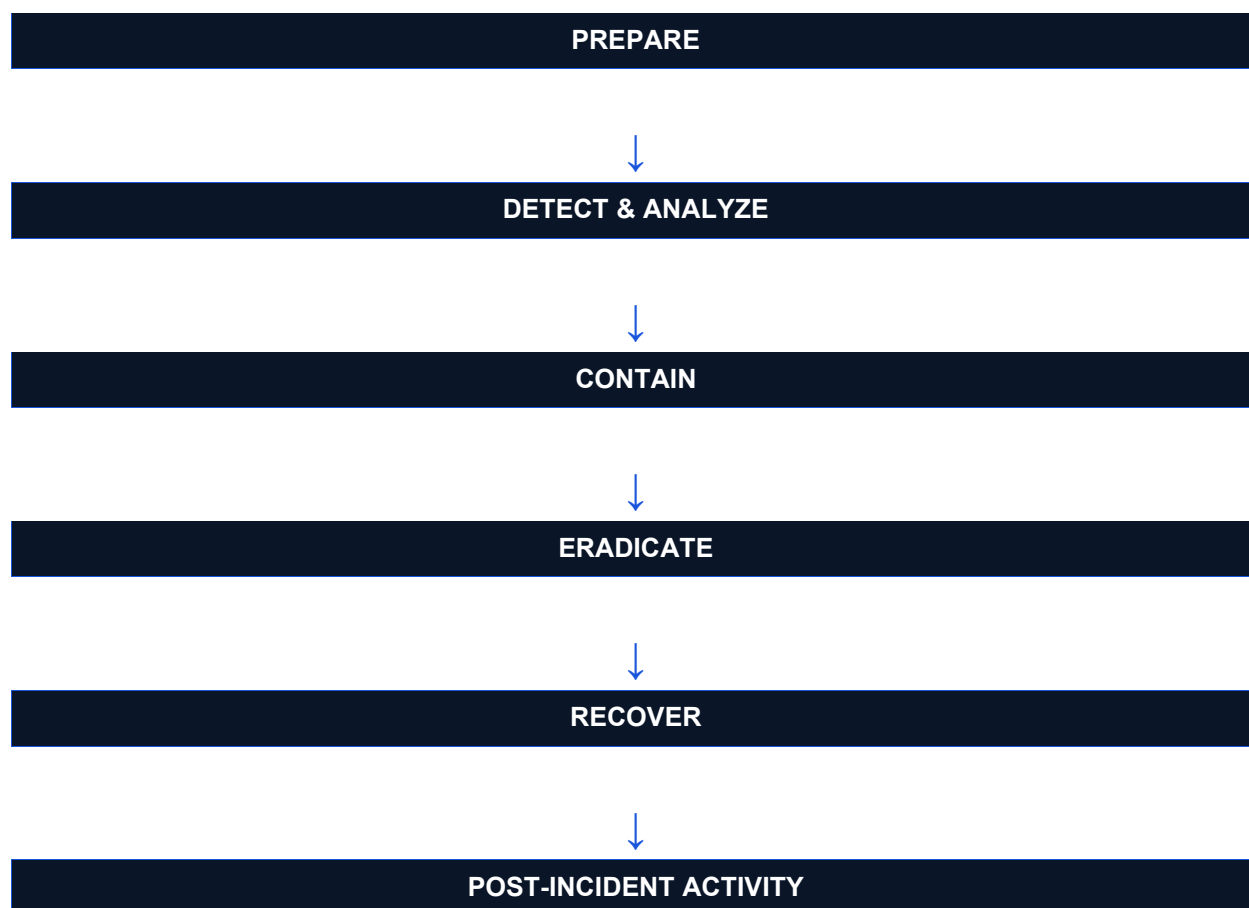
05. Incident Classification

Severity	Description	Example
Critical	Major business or security impact	Ransomware / major breach
High	Significant impact	Compromised privileged account
Medium	Limited impact	Malware on single endpoint
Low	Minimal impact	Suspicious email

This is intentionally a simple, four-tier classification. A detailed quantitative risk-scoring model is beyond the scope of this starter template.

06. Incident Response Lifecycle

This plan follows a six-phase lifecycle, conceptually aligned with NIST SP 800-61:



Phase	What Happens
Prepare	Establish plans, tools, training, and contacts before an incident occurs.
Detect & Analyze	Identify potential incidents and assess their scope, severity, and impact.
Contain	Limit the spread and impact of the incident while preserving evidence.
Eradicate	Remove the threat and the root cause from the environment.
Recover	Restore affected systems and services to normal operation.
Post-Incident Activity	Document lessons learned and track corrective actions.

07. Incident Identification & Initial Assessment

Incident Information

Incident ID	_____
Date/Time Detected	_____
Reported By	_____
Detection Source	_____
Affected System(s)	_____
Initial Description	_____

Initial Assessment

- What happened?
- When did it occur?
- What systems are affected?
- What information may be affected?
- Is the incident ongoing?
- Is immediate containment required?

08. Containment

Immediate Containment

- ☐ Isolate affected endpoint/system
- ☐ Disable compromised account
- ☐ Block malicious IP/domain
- ☐ Preserve relevant evidence

- ☐ Protect unaffected systems
- ☐ Escalate to incident response leadership

Short-Term Containment

- ☐ Apply temporary controls
- ☐ Segment affected systems
- ☐ Restrict privileged access
- ☐ Increase monitoring
- ☐ Coordinate with third parties

This template intentionally does not include technical commands or forensic procedures.

09. Eradication

Root Cause	_____
Threat Removed	_____
Systems Remediated	_____
Credentials Reset	_____
Vulnerabilities Addressed	_____

10. Recovery

- ☐ Restore systems
- ☐ Validate system integrity
- ☐ Monitor restored systems
- ☐ Confirm business functionality
- ☐ Remove temporary controls
- ☐ Obtain management approval
- ☐ Close incident

Recovery Date	_____
Systems Restored	_____
Validation Performed By	_____

11. Communications

Internal Communication — Who Needs to Know?

- Executive Management
- IT/Security
- Legal
- HR
- Employees

External Communication — Potential Parties

- Customers
- Vendors
- Regulators
- Law enforcement
- Cyber insurance provider
- External counsel
- CPA/auditor, where applicable

Audience	Who Communicates	Method	Timing	Approved By

This template does not include jurisdiction-specific notification language, since obligations depend on jurisdiction, industry, and the circumstances of the incident. Coordinate notification content and timing with Legal.

12. Evidence & Documentation

Evidence	Owner	Location	Date Collected	Notes
Logs	[Name]	[Location]	[Date]	
Screenshots	[Name]	[Location]	[Date]	
Alerts	[Name]	[Location]	[Date]	
Investigation Notes	[Name]	[Location]	[Date]	

Preserve relevant evidence in accordance with organizational procedures and applicable legal requirements.

13. Incident Closure

Closure Checklist

- ☐ Threat contained
- ☐ Root cause identified
- ☐ Remediation completed
- ☐ Systems restored
- ☐ Stakeholders notified
- ☐ Evidence documented
- ☐ Lessons learned completed
- ☐ Follow-up actions assigned

Incident Closure Summary

- What happened?
- What was the impact?
- How was the incident resolved?
- What improvements are required?

14. Post-Incident Review

Question	Response
What worked well?	
What did not work?	
What caused the incident?	
Were escalation procedures effective?	
Was communication effective?	
What controls should be improved?	
What actions are required?	

Corrective Action Tracker

Action	Owner	Priority	Due Date	Status

Action	Owner	Priority	Due Date	Status

15. Incident Contact Directory

Function	Primary Contact	Backup	Phone	Email
Incident Response				
IT/Security				
Executive				
Legal				
Communications				
HR				
Cyber Insurance				
External IR Provider				

16. From Plan to Practice

This template helps you establish your incident response foundation — documenting responsibilities, a lifecycle, classification, and structured response and post-incident workflows.

- Document responsibilities
- Establish a lifecycle
- Define classification
- Structure response
- Document incidents
- Organize post-incident actions

Explore the TSEC Professional Pack™

A complete incident response program: playbooks by incident type, tabletop exercise scenarios, a jurisdiction-aware notification matrix, and integration with your broader compliance program, built on the foundation in this template.

Explore professional compliance toolkits for SOC 2, ISO 27001, NIST CSF, NYDFS Part 500, HIPAA, COBIT 2019, PCI DSS, and other leading security and regulatory frameworks.

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Revision History

Version	Date	Author	Summary of Changes
1.0	September 2026	TSEC Risk & Cyber Advisory LLC	Initial publication of the Incident Response Plan Template.